Understanding Choice Authenticity and Player Agency in Road to Empress: A Mixed-Methods Study of Historically Adapted Narrative Games Among Chinese Young Players

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Abstract

Historically adapted narrative games present a unique design challenge regarding the balance between the fixed nature of historical events and the player's desire for interactive agency. This study investigates how young Chinese players interpret narrative cues, evaluate "choice authenticity," and negotiate the tension between historical fidelity and entertainment value in the game *Road to Empress*. Adopting a mixed-methods approach that integrates a qualitative analysis of 200 community reviews with semi-structured interviews with 6 participants, we find that for this demographic, the evaluative standard of authenticity shifts from strict "factual accuracy" to "cognitive authenticity". This standard prioritizes internal character logic and socio-political consistency over textbook precision. Results indicate that players do not reject historical determinism but strongly oppose arbitrary narrative mechanics, such as "fake choices," that render agency illusory. Furthermore, players experience an "ethical friction" between modern values and the ruthless demands of historical survival. We argue that successful historical adaptation relies on maintaining "cognitive dignity" by ensuring that fictional liberties respect the fundamental logic of the historical narrative to sustain player immersion. These findings offer theoretical insights into culturally situated player agency and actionable design implications for interactive historical storytelling.

1 Introduction

Interactive narrative-driven games have become a key cultural form through which players construct meanings, negotiate identities, and interpret complex socio-historical narratives [16, 28, 32]. Scholars argue that narrative games extend far beyond entertainment; they serve as experiential systems that enable players to enact agency, reflect on moral or emotional choices, and position themselves in relation to fictional or historical worlds [7, 15, 26]. Yet, as recent HCI work shows, players' interpretations of narrative cues are deeply shaped by their cultural context, lived experiences, and social identities, which is a pattern that is particularly evident in studies of gender games and certain gaming communities [11, 34, 35]. Within this broad category, historically adapted narrative-driven games occupy a particularly complex position. They not only require players to follow fictionalized events but also to reconcile these events with culturally embedded historical knowledge, moral expectations, and shared collective memory [7, 17]. As a result, questions of authenticity—whether a narrative moment, character action, or branching choice "feels historically plausible" become especially salient.

Although scholarship on narrative agency, historical authenticity, and cultural interpretation has grown substantially, little empirical research examines how players from specific cultural contexts interpret historically adapted narratives, or how their cultural proximity to the source material shapes expectations of coherence, plausibility, and moral logic of the game.

To address this gap, the present study examines *Road to Empress*, a widely discussed Chinese narrative-driven game adapted from the life of Wu Zetian who was the only female emperor in Chinese history. This title functions as a critical case: it is culturally visible, narratively ambitious, and heavily reliant on branching choice structures that invite player agency. The game's reinterpretation of historical figures and its controversial narrative deviations have sparked substantial debate in online communities, making it an ideal site for investigating how players judge choice authenticity: the perceived plausibility, coherence, and legitimacy of narrative decisions within a historically framed story world.

By integrating a community discourse analysis with semi-structured interviews, this study focuses on three research questions:

- RQ1. How do Chinese young players interpret key narrative elements in historically adapted narrative games?
- RQ2. How do these interpretations shape their evaluations of "choice authenticity" and perceptions of agency?
- RQ3. How do players negotiate the tension between

historical authenticity and entertainment value during play?

Rather than treating authenticity as an objective property of the text, we approach it as a player-driven interpretive process shaped by cultural knowledge, emotional investment, and expectations of how history "should" be represented in interactive media.

Although our study focuses on Chinese young players and a Chinese historical narrative game, the goal of this research is designed as an exploratory, pioneering investigation into how players interpret historically adapted interactive narratives, using *Road to Empress* as a critical case that makes underlying interpretive dynamics visible. Our intention is to support meaningful player agency and provide foundational insights that can inform the broader design of historical narrative-driven games, regardless of geographic or cultural setting. Thus, we position this work not as a culturally bounded analysis, but as an early step toward establishing conceptual and methodological directions for future research and design in interactive historical storytelling.

2 Background

Narrative-driven games have long been recognized as a medium in which players actively construct meaning through the interpretation of story events, character motivations, and branching decision structures [28, 32, 38]. Unlike linear historical fiction or documentary representation, interactive narratives require players to inhabit a protagonist's perspective, evaluate the plausibility of available choices, and negotiate the consequences of their actions within a designed story world [1, 10, 15, 26, 36]. This interpretive role becomes even more complex when narrative games adapt historical material. Historical narratives carry cultural memory, moral expectations, and widely shared understandings of what "could" or "should" have happened. As a result, historically adapted games must navigate a delicate balance between creative storytelling and fidelity to collectively recognized historical logic.

Research in game studies and digital humanities has shown that authenticity in historical games is not equivalent to factual accuracy [9]. Instead, authenticity emerges through atmospheric coherence, narrative framing, and the perceived plausibility of character motivations within cultural and historical contexts [19, 24]. Players evaluate historical narratives through their own interpretive frameworks [8]. When games deviate from widely held interpretations of key figures or events, players may question not only the factual accuracy of the story but also its moral coherence or its respect for the cultural significance of the past [13, 29]. These interpretive tensions become especially salient in contexts where history is deeply woven into national identity.

Although there is growing research on how games represent history and give players narrative agency, we still know little about how players from different cultural backgrounds understand historical interactive stories [3, 11, 34]. Existing studies rarely explore whether players who feel culturally close to the historical material judge the story choices as more believable or appropriate than others [7]. Much of the previous work focuses on theory or game design, rather than on how players actually interpret narrative limits or decide whether branching paths feel convincing . We also lack research on how players balance their desire for freedom with the fixed outcomes of real historical events. These gaps make it harder to understand how historical narrative games help culturally situated players create meaning from what they play.

Road to Empress offers a critical site for addressing these questions. As a popular Chinese narrative game based on the life of Wu Zetian, it exemplifies the design challenges of adapting culturally significant history into an interactive format. The game's reliance on branching structures, its reinterpretation of well-known historical figures, and the considerable debate it has generated within player communities make it a powerful case for examining how authenticity, agency, and narrative expectation intersect. By understanding how players interpret such games, we can better articulate the design tensions inherent in historical narratives.

3 Literature Review

Prior research on narrative-driven games has extensively examined how players experience agency, meaning-making, and decision-making within interactive story worlds [28, 31, 32]. Foundational scholars such as Murray argue that interactive narratives position players as co-creators of meaning, shaping interpretation through action [28]. Similarly, Ryan emphasizes that interactive stories require players to construct causal relationships and evaluate narrative coherence [31, 32]. Building on these foundations, Salen and Zimmerman highlight that meaningful play emerges when system feedback aligns with player interpretation and expectation [33].

Recent empirical work reinforces the centrality of choice design. Yin and Xiao demonstrate that choices influence immersion, moral reflection, and player motivation, underscoring how branching structures act as interpretive devices [41]. Complementing this, Carstensdottir et al. show that perceptions of agency are shaped not solely by system architecture but by social investment, genre conventions, and individual differences, positioning agency as a culturally mediated experience [6]. Their findings align with additional research arguing that emotional investment, identification with characters, and narrative framing strongly affect how agency is perceived [3, 20] .

Despite substantial attention to agency, historically adapted narrative-driven games remain undertheorized. Burgess and Jones observe that players frequently conflate historical authenticity with historical accuracy, assuming credibility de-

pends on factual adherence [5]. However, Stirling and Wood argue that authenticity arises less from factual precision than from affective engagement with atmosphere, spatial design, and thematic coherence [37]. This position aligns with work by Chapman, who frames historical games as interpretive constructions shaped by cultural memory rather than empirical truth [7]. Similarly, MacCallum-Stewart describes authenticity as negotiated between players, designers, and shared cultural understandings [23].

Historical interpretation in games is further influenced by cultural context. Research shows that players rely on culturally informed frameworks—education, collective narratives, and popular representations—when evaluating plausibility in historical games [8, 17]. As Lammes argues, players' interpretations of game worlds are shaped by cultural and spatial practices [21]. Her work indicates that cultural frameworks shape not only how players understand historical content but also how they interact with game systems and spatial structures. Yet, despite this theoretical recognition, empirical studies that specifically examine how different cultural groups interpret and negotiate historical game narratives remain limited. Mukherjee similarly highlights that postcolonial and culturally situated interpretations of history in games are underexplored, calling for more player-centered analysis [27].

Beyond these concerns, scholars have noted that cultural frameworks influence not only the evaluation of authenticity but also how players interpret agency within historical narratives [12, 39, 40]. For example, research suggests that the degree to which players perceive agency as appropriate or meaningful depends in part on culturally informed understandings of historical inevitability, moral legitimacy, and the roles individuals are imagined to play within historical processes [4, 25]. Some cultures emphasize structural or collective explanations for historical change, while others foreground individual heroism or personal choice [14, 22]. These differences can shape how players assess branching narratives: a choice that feels dramatically compelling in one cultural context may feel implausible or morally incoherent in another [14, 30].

Collectively, this body of work reveals a significant gap in scholarship: although cultural frameworks are known to shape interpretations of historical media broadly, we still lack empirical research examining how culturally situated players make sense of authenticity, agency, and narrative plausibility in historically adapted games. Addressing this gap is essential for understanding not only how players interpret historical narratives in interactive form but also how designers might better navigate the tensions between creative adaptation and cultural fidelity in historical game design.

4 Methodology

This study adopts a mixed-methods research design to examine how young Chinese players interpret choice authenticity and player agency in historically adapted narrative-driven games. Combining qualitative analysis of large-scale community discourse with in-depth semi-structured interviews allows us to capture both collective patterns of interpretation and individual meaning-making processes. This methodological approach is well suited for investigating subjective constructs such as authenticity, agency, and historical plausibility, which emerge through players' lived experiences and narrative engagement rather than through isolated behavioral metrics.

4.1 Research Design

We employed two complementary qualitative data sources. First, we conducted a qualitative content analysis of approximately 200 publicly available, filtered Steam reviews of *Road to Empress*. These reviews provide organically generated player reflections, capturing spontaneous evaluations of narrative logic, historical adaptation, and perceived agency. Second, we conducted semi-structured online interviews with players to obtain deeper insight into players' reasoning processes, emotional responses, and interpretive frameworks when engaging with historically constrained narrative choices. The triangulation of these two data sources enables a more robust understanding of how cultural knowledge and personal values shape players' interpretations of narrative agency.

4.2 Study Context

Road to Empress is a historically adapted narrative-driven game based on the life of Wu Zetian, the only female emperor in Chinese history. The game situates players within a branching narrative structure that combines historically grounded events with interactive decision-making. While certain historical outcomes are fixed, players are offered multiple decision points that influence character relationships, political trajectories, and narrative consequences. This design makes the game a particularly suitable case for examining tensions between historical authenticity, narrative coherence, and player agency.

4.3 Participant Recruitment and Criteria

Interview participants were recruited through multiple online platforms, including the Steam community, Bilibili, game-specific forums, and Discord servers. Recruitment materials described the study as an academic investigation into player experience and historical narrative interpretation. Participation was voluntary, and no financial compensation was provided.

To be eligible for participation, individuals had to meet the following inclusion criteria: (1) be between 18 and 30 years old; (2) identify as Chinese or demonstrate familiarity with Chinese history; (3) have played *Road to Empress*; (4) have either completed the main storyline or experienced the vast majority of the core narrative content; and (5) be

able to conduct the interview in Mandarin or English. We excluded participants who were under 18 or over 30, who had only completed the tutorial or early chapters, or who had not directly played the game and instead relied solely on video playthroughs.

A total of six participants meeting these criteria were interviewed.

4.4 Interview Procedure

Semi-structured interviews were conducted via online voice calls and lasted approximately 45–60 minutes. The interview guide was organized into five thematic sections: (1) gaming background and familiarity with Chinese history; (2) general gameplay experience and narrative interpretation; (3) perceptions of choice authenticity and agency; (4) evaluations of the tension between historical authenticity and entertainment value; and (5) closing reflections and demographic confirmation. This structure allowed for both consistency across interviews and flexibility to pursue emergent themes raised by participants.

All interviews were conducted with informed consent and were audio-recorded for transcription and analysis. The full interview guide is provided in the Appendix.

4.5 Data Analysis

We analyzed both Steam reviews and interview transcripts using a multi-stage qualitative coding process. A shared codebook was developed by integrating theoretical concepts from prior literature—such as authenticity, agency, and historical adaptation—with inductively derived patterns observed in the data.

Coding proceeded in three stages. First, we conducted in-vivo coding to preserve participants' original language and capture unexpected or culturally specific expressions. Second, we applied open coding to segment the data into smaller meaning units and label recurring concepts (e.g., "fake choice," "forced death," "romanticization of history"). Third, we conducted axial and thematic coding to group related codes into higher-level analytical themes, including historical authenticity, narrative logic, emotional investment, and constrained agency. These themes were explicitly mapped to our research questions (RQ1–RQ3) [18].

To enhance analytical rigor, at least two researchers independently coded subsets of the data. Discrepancies were discussed and resolved through consensus, and inter-rater reliability was monitored throughout the process. Findings from Steam reviews and interview data were triangulated to identify convergent patterns and contextual differences, allowing us to examine how cultural familiarity with history shapes perceptions of narrative authenticity and agency across different modes of player expression [2].

5 Result

In this section, we present the findings derived from the analysis of 200 player comments and in-depth interviews with 6 participants. The results are organized into three main themes corresponding to our research questions. First, we examine how players project their historical cognition to evaluate narrative rationality (RQ1). Second, we analyze how players negotiate agency and perceive the authenticity of choices within a deterministic historical framework (RQ2). Finally, we explore the tension between the demand for historical respect and the desire for entertainment value (RQ3). Across these themes, a central pattern emerges: young Chinese players are not passive consumers of history but active negotiators who constantly measure the game's "internal logic" against their own "cultural schema."

5.1 RQ1: Projection of Historical Cognition and Negotiation of Narrative Rationality

Regarding the first research question—how young Chinese players interpret key narrative elements in historically adapted narrative games—our analysis reveals a core phenomenon: players do not passively accept the "parallel universe" established by the game. Instead, they actively mobilize their existing Historical Cultural Cognition as a benchmark to evaluate the game narrative. This interpretive process is primarily manifested in the resistance to the "de-politicization" of historical figures and the rigorous demand for the "logical consistency" of fictional plots.

5.1.1 The "De-politicization" of Historical Figures and the Defense of Character Dignity

Analysis based on community discourse indicates that players possess high sensitivity toward the adaptation of renowned historical figures, particularly Wu Zetian. Although players understand that games may employ adaptations for entertainment purposes, they strongly oppose reducing complex political figures to singular objects of romance, viewing this as an offense to historical dignity. For instance, regarding the highly controversial romantic subplot between Li Tai and Wu Zetian, community discourse was filled with dissatisfaction. Players criticized the game for manufacturing what they termed "*industrial artificial sweetener*" *(gong ye tang jing)* (*C12*) to forcibly create conflict. Many lamented that the adaptation *"reduced a cold-blooded stateswoman to a love-struck maiden"* (*C145*), which fundamentally "*erased her political agency*" (*C88*).

Interview data further corroborates this perspective. Participants often entered the game with a preconceived notion of Wu Zetian as an "*ambitious politician*" (*P2*) or a "*powerful empress*." (*P3*) However, the image presented in the game created a significant dissonance with these expectations.

One interviewee expressed disappointment, noting that the in-game character resembled a "clever young girl" rather than possessing the "imperial temperament" recorded in historical texts. Another participant remarked:

"*In my understanding, Wu Zetian should be a commanding, decisive, and ambitious empress, given she was the only female emperor in China... But in the game, this is not very obvious; instead, there is a greater focus on emotional lines and the portrayal of traditional female images.*" (*P2*)

This cognitive dissonance leads players to perceive the game as attempting to "sentimentalize" serious history. As one comment sharply pointed out, "*this isn't adaptation, it is a disrespect to history under the guise of romance*" (*C34*). Players' interpretation of narrative authenticity is primarily founded on whether core character traits, such as ambition and political maneuvering, are respectfully restored.

5.1.2 The Boundary of Fictional Narratives: From "Historical Accuracy" to "Logical Consistency"

Our research finds that players do not inherently reject fiction; what they find intolerable is the Logical Collapse caused by fictional elements. In community discussions, players severely criticized inconsistencies in characterization, such as Li Tai being established as a ruthless political schemer yet acting irrationally and emotionally in the romance route. This practice of sacrificing character logic to serve the plot was viewed by players as "*insulting the player's intelligence*" (*C103*) and causing the character's persona to "*completely collapse*" (*beng ta*) (*C56*).

Evidence from interviews demonstrates that when adapted plots violate specific Socio-historical Logic, players experience a strong sense of "breaking immersion" (chuxi). Participants specifically pointed to scenes in the Li Tai subplot, noting that allowing a concubine frequent contact with an outside male within the strict confines of the imperial palace is unreasonable. Community comments ridiculed this setting, asking "*Do the palace guards of the Tang Dynasty simply not exist?*" (*C178*) and labeling the plot as "*a modern idol drama forcibly wrapped in ancient costumes*" *(C09*). This "unreasonableness" refers not merely to a deviation from historical textbooks, but to a violation of the basic power structures and survival rules of that era. As one interviewee described:

"*Leaving aside why the strict imperial palace would allow a concubine like Wu Zetian to frequently contact an outside male... I just felt it was a bit absurd and couldn't immerse myself (dai ru)... When it doesn't match history, it feels 'out of place' (chuxi).*" (*P1*)

Therefore, the interpretive standard for historical adaptation among young Chinese players has shifted from a purely "textual research" approach (demanding complete alignment with facts) to a pursuit of "internal logical authenticity." They may accept artistic processing of details but reject "*radical modifications*" (*mo gai*) (*C192*) that disrupt character consistency and the logic of the historical environment.

5.2 RQ2: Choice Authenticity and Perceptions of Agency

Regarding the second research question—how interpretations of narrative shape evaluations of "choice authenticity" and perceptions of agency—our analysis indicates a significant shift in players' evaluative standards. Players prioritize internal "cognitive logic" over external "historical facts" and evaluate agency based on the "legitimacy of failure" rather than the ability to alter historical outcomes.

5.2.1 Cognitive Authenticity: Internal Logic Over Factual Accuracy

Findings suggest that for young Chinese players, the primary criterion for "authenticity" in choices is not the strict replication of official history, but the self-consistency of character logic. Players exhibited a high tolerance for minor historical deviations but were extremely critical of options that caused a "collapse of intelligence" (jiang zhi). Community feedback frequently labeled such options as "*OOC*" (*Out of Character*) (*C45*), complaining that certain choices were "*forcing the protagonist to act stupid just to advance the plot*" (*C128*).

Data from interviews reveals that when decision-making logic is opaque, players feel their agency is diminished, reducing the experience to a random guess rather than a strategic engagement. Comments described this frustration as "*playing a guessing game with the developer's mind rather than playing the game itself*" (*C19*). As one participant explained regarding a difficult in-game choice:

> "*I couldn't understand the tendency behind the options... and didn't understand what consequences my decision would bring. Therefore, I couldn't weigh the pros and cons through reason. It felt like the options lacked risk warnings, giving me a sense that the method of death was random.*" (*P3*)

This indicates that "choice authenticity" relies on the transparency of the causal link between the player's judgment and the narrative consequence.

5.2.2 The Boundary of Agency: The "Legitimacy of Failure"

In negotiating the tension between historical determinism and player freedom, players categorized in-game failure into two distinct experiences: "Justified Failure" and "Arbitrary Failure."

Justified Failure: When failure results from a player's strategic error and aligns with the ruthless logic of court politics, it paradoxically enhances immersion and the perception of agency. Players praised this unforgiving difficulty as

"*startling at every step*" (*bu bu jing xin*) (*C82*), noting that it authentically reflected the high stakes of the era. The "death" becomes a validation of the game's logical depth. As one interviewee described:

> "*The logic and consistency of the choices are very strong. Every time I died, I would exclaim 'Aha, so that's why' (yuanlai ruci)... I could truly appreciate that it was impossible for ancients to slack off in the palace; surviving was truly difficult.*" (*P4*)

Arbitrary Failure: Conversely, agency is disrupted when the game enforces a "historical correction" through inexplicable plot twists, regardless of the player's efforts. This is frequently perceived as a "fake choice." Community discussions vehemently criticized these moments as "*plot kills*" (*ju qing sha*) (*C189*), where players felt their strategic efforts were "*rendered a joke by the script*" (*C56*). Referring to the controversial "Rescue Bianji" storyline, a participant expressed frustration at the futility of their agency:

> "*I selected every single branch, but every good strategy would fail due to various sudden accidents... simply because the plot required it. This made me feel my choices were meaningless; it was death either way.*" (*P1*)

5.2.3 Ethical Friction of a Dual Identity

Furthermore, we observed a profound "ethical friction" between players' modern morality and the demands of historical survival. When the game's pursuit of "historical accuracy" necessitates cruel actions (e.g., infanticide or betrayal) to advance the plot, players experience significant cognitive dissonance. Comments revealed that players often felt "*psychologically uncomfortable*" (*C102*) or even felt they were being "*morally kidnapped*" (*C13*) by the game's requirements.

While some players attempt to align completely with the protagonist's persona to avoid this conflict, noting that "*we are on the same side*" (*P2*), others struggle when the game forces them to compromise their modern values for the sake of "*historical correctness*" (*P4, P6*). This friction suggests that agency is not only about control over the plot but also about the alignment between the player's ethical self and the historical role they inhabit.

5.3 RQ3: Negotiating the Tension between Historical Authenticity and Entertainment Value

Regarding the third research question, we explored how players negotiate the tension between "respecting history" and "pursuing entertainment." Our analysis of community discourse and interview data reveals that this tension is not a zero-sum game but manifests as two distinct experiential pathways: confirming the weight of history through "powerlessness" versus pursuing gameplay satisfaction through the "power to rewrite."

5.3.1 The Paradox of Immersion: Experiencing History through "Powerlessness"

In community discussions, the controversial "Rescue Bianji" storyline served as a focal point for observing this tension. Historically, Bianji's execution is an immutable fact; however, in the game, many players attempted to find a lifeline through strategic choices.

Surprisingly, our analysis indicates that for a segment of players, the frustration of "being unable to change history despite all efforts" became a key catalyst for enhanced immersion. By repeatedly striking against the "iron wall" of history within the game mechanics, players profoundly experienced the cruelty of imperial society and individual insignificance. Comments described this painful experience as "*swallowing glass shards*" (*C92*), yet admitted that this pain made the story "*unforgettable*" (*C92*). As one player remarked in a lengthy review:

> "*I refused to give up—I'm stubborn, so I tried every single route to save Bianji, but every path still led to death. It was an immersive experience that truly showed me what it means to have no way out... Even when you give everything, even risk your own life, you still can't change fate. I felt the helplessness of that era so deeply.*" (*C14*)

Interviewee P1 also expressed a similar view, arguing that "*historical determinism*" is the source of this genre's unique aesthetic. Community members echoed this, stating that "*happy endings in such a heavy historical context would feel cheap*" (*C105*) and that the tragedy is exactly what gives the narrative its "*historical weight*" (*C166*).

5.3.2 The Rebellion of Gameplay: The Desire to "Rewrite Destiny"

However, another group of players voiced a starkly different perspective in the community. They argued that as a *game*, the core promise should be "empowerment." If strict adherence to historical facts renders all player choices invalid, the interactivity loses its meaning. Many players expressed their "*lingering regret*" (*yi nan ping*) (*C33*) regarding the inevitable tragedy, questioning why the game offered choices if the outcome was fixed. One comment fiercely argued, "*If I wanted to watch a documentary, I wouldn't be playing a game; I play to defy fate!*" (*C180*).

The pilot study recorded strong protests from players regarding this constraint:

> "*Since we're playing a game, why can't there be more freedom? Why must everything strictly follow*

history? ... I tried every option to save him, and every single one still led to death. Isn't this basically forcing the heroine to fall out with Gaoyang?" (*C42*)

Interviewee P2 further elaborated on this stance from the perspective of "player rights." While acknowledging the need to respect the historical background, P2 argued that the final decision-making power should reside with the player:

"*Since it is a game, the power to decide the final ending should be handed over to the player. I believe there needs to be a channel for players to achieve their goals... I prefer that the game allows players to rewrite history through their efforts.*" (*P2*)

5.3.3 The Bottom Line of Negotiation: Refusing "Cognitive Deception"

Despite the divergence on whether endings should be alterable, our interviews revealed a common psychological baseline among players: "entertainment adaptation" must not constitute "cognitive deception."

Players accept artistic processing to fill historical gaps (such as inner monologues) but strongly resent the distortion of known basic facts solely to create dramatic conflict. Community discourse often labeled such distortions as "*tampering with history indiscriminately*" (*luan gai li shi*) (*C199*). Interviewee P1 clearly delineated this boundary, noting that historical games imply a contract of "knowledge dissemination":

"*If the ending is completely changed to force causality, I won't appreciate it. Because I play this type of game partly due to its historical theme, I take it seriously. When I discover that the knowledge I ingested is false, I feel a sense of being deceived.*" (*P1*)

This suggests that while young Chinese players seek entertainment value, they maintain a vigilance regarding the authenticity of historical knowledge. As one comment summarized, "*Adaptation is not nonsense; playfulness is not humor*" (*gaibian bushi luanbian*) (*C07*). The "entertainment" they seek is a deduction based on respectful historical logic, not the arbitrary consumption of history.

6 Discussion

Drawing on Chinese players' interpretations of, and gameplay experiences with, the historical narrative game Road to Empress, this study argues that authenticity for players is not reducible to strict fidelity to historical fact. Players are acutely aware that the historical ending has already been fixed, for instance, the macro-historical certainty that Wu Zetian will eventually become empress. At the same time, they still expect to exercise meaningful choice along the way and express strong dissatisfaction with branches that appear interactive but are, in practice, tightly pre-scripted. This finding both responds to and extends existing debates on authenticity in historical games. Prior research typically distinguishes between different dimensions such as historical accuracy, emotional realism, and immersion. The present study further shows that, in actual play, players also incorporate into their authenticity judgments whether the game has acceptable consistency between history and adaptation, considering the experience of authenticity and autonomy.

6.1 Authenticity as Negotiated, Not Given: Dialogue with Existing Literature

At the level of mechanics, players are particularly sensitive to the phenomenon of fake branches. They repeatedly point out that, while the game's marketing highlights multiple endings and highly branched structures, the actual design often undermines consequential choice through devices. The gap between this kind of quantitative branching and the qualitative experience of meaningful choice leads players to feel played or even deceived. This directly echoes critiques of the illusion of choice in interactive narrative from most of the players who actively expose and reject this illusion.

With respect to historical adaptation and character construction, the findings both align with and complicate existing scholarship. On the one hand, players' criticism that the game "uses Wu Zetian as a selling point but primarily tells a romance story" closely parallels analyses of film, television, and online fiction that diagnose a pattern of "historical skin, romantic core. On the other hand, this study foregrounds a tension that has received relatively limited systematic discussion: when the protagonist is a woman endowed with substantial political power and historical controversy, players' tolerance for the political storyline being overshadowed by the romance plot, or for the protagonist's political ascent being diluted or erased, declines sharply. They interpret such moves not merely as exercises of "adaptive license" but as erasures of women's political subjectivity in history. Moreover, accusations of false empowerment closely resonate with recent gender scholarship critiquing popular culture texts that invoke a female lead while enacting depoliticization in practice. These are works that ostensibly center a female protagonist and even endow her with a strong, emotionally intense persona, yet structurally strip her of the pursuit and exercise of power, rewriting her as someone who failed to present relevant characteristics. Players explicitly note that if a historical male ruler were written as ascending the throne "purely for the sake of a lover" and being indifferent to governance, audiences would immediately read this as absurd, whereas similar characterizations seem more readily accepted for female figures. This asymmetry reveals a gendered double standard embedded within the

narrative.

The study also finds that players' strong appreciation for secondary characters and "ordinary people" indicates that they are not simply pursuing grand narratives or an "imperial viewpoint." On the contrary, when the game carefully depicts characters such as Xixin, Rui'er, and Duruo—their everyday positions within structures of power and their moral struggles—players describe these representations as more real and relatable. Through these minor figures, players perceive a broader social environment and ethically ambiguous zones. This pattern converges with trends in historical narrative research that advocate entering history through bottom-up perspectives and micro-histories. In terms of affect and immersion, players simultaneously deliver scathing criticisms, describing the plot as melodramatic and logically incoherent, while also acknowledging that they felt tormented to the point of anger, helplessness, and even tears. This "love-hate" feedback suggests that high dramatic intensity and emotional involvement can partially buffer or even temporarily mask logical issues, at least within the time frame of immediate experience. Meanwhile, players consistently praise the game's use of camera work, pacing, and the seamless embedding of choices into the visual frame, describing these long-series-drama formal qualities as markedly enhancing the sense of presence. This provides a concrete case for how formal newness can coexist with substantively old narrative conventions: even when the underlying plot structure is relatively conventional, the formal experimentation of interactive audiovisual design can still produce a strong sense of immersion.

Taken together, the study supports a view of authenticity in historical games as negotiated rather than given. Authenticity is not a unidimensional question of fidelity to the chronicle but the outcome of ongoing negotiation between players and text across multiple dimensions, including historical knowledge, character coherence, the consequences of choice, gender politics, and emotional cost.

6.2 Design Implications for Historical Narrative Games

Building on these findings, we propose several design implications for historical narrative games.

6.2.1 Designing Historical Inevitability as Multiple Paths to a Shared Endpoint

Players do not expect to overturn key historical events they already know, such as the inevitable death of a particular character or the occurrence of a coup, and they neither can nor seek to change what is written in the chronicles, but they care deeply about the process through which they arrive at those endpoints. From a design perspective, this suggests treating historical inevitability as a fixed outcome that can be reached through multiple differentiated pathways, rather than as a structure in which everything plays out the same regardless of player choice. For key historical facts that are perceived as non-negotiable, designers can allow players to reach the same outcome via routes that differ substantially in plot events, relationship dynamics, and moral costs, and can require different value trade-offs along these routes, such as whom to sacrifice, whom to protect, and which political strategies to adopt, so that the same ending unfolds as distinct life histories and emotional trajectories at the level of lived experience. Under such a design, players' decision space around how to arrive at the historical ending is respected, and they can feel that they are co-authoring different versions of a story that nonetheless converge on a shared endpoint, rather than being told implicitly that their choices do not matter. By contrast, the prevalence of fake branches in current designs, where choices differ only at the interface level but converge on functionally identical outcomes, makes players acutely aware that their decisions primarily consume time and emotion without generating structural consequences, which not only diminishes their sense of agency but also erodes their trust in the work's authenticity and sincerity.

6.2.2 Aligning Key Characters' Actions with Value Logics and Character Consistency

Players are not uniformly opposed to fictionalizing historical figures; what provokes strong backlash is not fictionalization itself, but revisions that violate the core value logic that has been established for a character across historical records and within the game's own text. Many players, for example, can accept the invention of quotidian interactions and intimate relationships for Wu Zetian, yet find it difficult to accept portrayals of her as lacking political ambition and living primarily for love, because these depictions are perceived as contradicting both historical knowledge and the internal setup of the narrative. Accordingly, character design needs to articulate a clear core value axis for each key figure, such as a desire for power, a sense of duty to state and family, erotic desire, or moral ideals, and important decisions at major narrative junctures should remain consistent with this axis so that the character's actions appear coherent rather than arbitrary or convenience-driven. Within this framework, the text can still engage in warm fictionalization at the level of detail by adding everyday scenes, specific emotional exchanges, and nuanced interpersonal relationships, as long as these invented elements are embedded in a plausible political context and gendered power structure and do not reduce historical holders of power to figures who merely struggle emotionally in a depoliticized way. Similarly, male characters should not be flattened into one-dimensional antagonists or disposable tools, as such simplification undermines the overall persuasiveness of the narrative; players explicitly note that figures such as the crown prince are written as uniformly villainous or scummy,

which neither reflects historical complexity nor sustains a balanced representation of power and gender. Efforts to empower a female protagonist should therefore avoid relying on the simple denigration of male characters as a means of relative elevation and instead foreground multi-directional, historically situated power relations in which different actors possess both agency and compromise.

6.2.3 Using "Modes" as an Interface for Negotiating Authenticity: A Hybrid Branching Structure

The findings also invite a rethinking of branching structure design through the lens of mode combination to address players' polarized expectations between historical inevitability and emotionally compensatory fate reversal. Rather than simply offering two segregated narrative lines, such as a strictly historical accuracy line versus a fully rewritten fate line, designers can construct an architecture that interweaves two modal tendencies: one that adheres more closely to historical records at key junctures, and another that permits greater latitude for rewriting fate, allowing these modes to intersect around major plot points so that players repeatedly confront decisions between following the chronicle and overturning fate, instead of making a single binary choice at the outset. Concretely, the game can set an initial orientation in which players choose a tendency that leans toward historical fidelity or toward fate-alteration, thereby accommodating preferences for experiencing a chronicle-aligned route or a more speculative rewrite route and enabling researchers to observe how prior expectations shape subsequent authenticity judgements. At pivotal narrative nodes, diegetic or meta-diegetic cues such as a historian's voice-over, omens, or characters' premonitions can explicitly signal the nature of competing branches, for instance, indicating that one branch follows the chronicle while another attempts to reverse fate, and players can be allowed to override their initial orientation at these moments, so that even those who began in a historically leaning mode can choose to defy the heavens at particular points, and vice versa. In such a design, mode ceases to be a purely technical difficulty setting and instead becomes an explicit interface through which players and text negotiate authenticity, turning each decision to follow the chronicle or rewrite fate into an occasion for renegotiating, within a specific narrative situation, what counts as real and what counts as reasonable.

6.2.4 Ensuring that High Dramatic Intensity and Emotional Involvement Support, Rather than Obscure, Logic and History

The study further indicates that high dramatic tension and emotional volatility can substantially deepen players' engagement, but that over-reliance on sensational events, frequent deaths, and extreme plot twists may intensify concerns about logical coherence and historical distortion. From a design standpoint, one response is to relocate some of the most intense and spectacular events to more open-ended, fate-altering routes, framing these as more fictional experimental spaces in which expectations of historical authenticity are lowered in advance. In routes that adhere more closely to the historical record, designers can moderate the frequency of deaths and extreme reversals, instead generating tension through subtler power struggles and emotional negotiations among characters, thereby maintaining narrative intensity while reinforcing logical and historical plausibility. Such strategies can help address the imbalance that players currently describe, where the game is formally immersive and tense but increasingly misaligned with their expectations of historical narrative.

6.3 Limitations and Future Directions

In terms of research design, the study deliberately focuses on young Chinese players and does not treat this as an unavoidable limitation, since this choice enables in-depth analysis within a cultural context where players' own histories and identity formations are closely entangled with the game's themes. At the same time, this focus introduces several constraints: the data are drawn from a single game, *Road to Empress*, which is both publicly visible and culturally sensitive in China, and participants were recruited mainly via online platforms such as Steam and Bilibili, which tend to attract active, outspoken, and often more critical players, potentially underrepresenting the perspectives of quieter or non-participating players. Many of the mechanisms identified—such as strong aversion to fake branches, low tolerance for specific forms of fictionalizing historical figures, and heightened sensitivity to a symbolic figure like Wu Zetian—are closely tied to cultural proximity, in the sense that players not only know this history cognitively but are also affectively invested in it. In contexts of greater cultural distance, for example, non-Chinese players engaging with the same game or Chinese players engaging with games based on other countries' histories, these mechanisms may manifest differently, weaken, or even reverse. Consequently, the findings should not be directly generalized across cultural settings, age groups, or genres of historical games, and future research can test and extend these propositions through cross-cultural comparison, multi-case studies of games with different historical settings and narrative forms, and multi-method approaches that combine qualitative interviews and comment analysis with surveys and gameplay log data to more systematically quantify relationships between players' choice behaviour, mode preferences, and evaluations of authenticity. Overall, the study treats *Road to Empress* as a critical case for examining how Chinese players, when confronted with interactive texts that are deeply entangled with their histories and gender politics, actively participate in the co-production of authenticity through close critique of mechanics, characters, and narrative, and it calls for future work to continue

probing the applicability and limits of these findings across a broader spectrum of cultural contexts and game types.

7 Conclusion

This study examined how young Chinese players navigate the tension between historical fidelity and interactive agency in *Road to Empress*. Our findings reveal that for this demographic, "authenticity" is defined less by strict factual replication and more by the internal consistency of character logic and socio-political rules. Players do not inherently reject the constraints of historical determinism; rather, they reject arbitrary narrative mechanics that obscure causal transparency and render agency illusory. Ultimately, we argue that the successful adaptation of history relies on maintaining "cognitive dignity"—ensuring that while fictional liberties are taken for entertainment, they must respect the fundamental logic of the historical narrative to avoid disrupting the player's negotiated immersion. These insights offer actionable guidance for future historical game design.

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A Appendix i Consent Form

- Study Title: Players' Experience and Interpretation of History-adapted Narrative Games

- Principal Investigator: Ziying Wang(zw315@duke.edu)

- Other Investigators: Zi'ang Chen(zc17@duke.edu), Yihong Lin(yl999@duke.edu), Michael Hayford(mqh6@duke.edu)

Key Information

Summary: Thank you for your interest in this study. We are researchers at Duke University. This survey study aims to explore the way young Chinese gamers interpret historical narrative-driven games, as well as their perceptions of "choice authenticity" and a sense of agency in games.

Procedures: In this interview, you will be asked some questions that will cover your feelings about key plot points, the trade-offs between historical authenticity and entertainment, and perceptions of authenticity in your choices. It will last approximately 45-60 minutes and will be recorded and transcribed. All data is anonymized and stored securely to be used for this study only.

Participant Requirements: Participants must be Chinese native speakers, aged between 18-25, studying in the US, and have narrative gaming experience.

Risks: We do not expect this survey to pose any harm or discomfort to participants. However, this interview may involve discussions of historical and cultural beliefs or values that may cause mild mental discomfort.

Benefits: There are no direct benefits to participants.

Compensation: There is no monetary reward in this study.

Confidentiality: We do not collect personally identifiable information through the entire study. All interview recordings will be stored in Duke Box, an encrypted cloud storage approved by Duke University. The de-tokenized data may be

used for academic publication or future related research. Data without information that could Page 32 of 44 directly identify you might be used in future research or shared with other researchers

Voluntariness: Your participation is voluntary. You can also stop the interview at any time, for any reason.

Right to Ask Questions Contact Information: If you have any questions about this study, desire additional information, or wish to withdraw your participation, please contact the Principal Investigator by e-mail in accordance with the contact information listed at the beginning of this consent form. For questions about your rights, please contact the Duke University Campus Institutional Review Board at 919-684-3030 or campusirb@duke.edu. It will be helpful if you include Protocol ID xxxx-xxxx in your communication.

I am 18 years or older.

Yes

No

I have read and I understand the information above.

Yes

No

I want to participate in this survey and continue with the task.

Yes

No

Appenxi ii Questionnaire: Chinese Young Players' Experiences with Historical Narrative-Driven Games

Instruction:

This questionnaire is part of the study *Chinese Young Players' Experiences with Historical Narrative-Driven Games*. We greatly appreciate your interest in participating in this research, and we hope that you will find this questionnaire straightforward and easy to complete. Your answers are extremely important to us to ensure that participants meet the study's eligibility criteria.

Participation in this study is entirely voluntary. All information you provide will be kept strictly confidential, and Duke University may protect the research team from being required to release any identifying information about you. Please note that, as required by law, we must report any credible evidence of serious harm or abuse to appropriate authorities, although this survey does not ask about such topics.

The questions in this form should be answered by you personally. You may ask for assistance if needed, but responses should reflect your own experiences and perspectives. Most questions can be answered by checking only one choice or by filling in the blank space provided. If a question does not apply to you, you may skip it and it will simply continue to the next question in order.

If you have any questions about this questionnaire or the study, please contact the research team by email at: zw315@duke.edu

Q1. Please enter your age (in numbers):

_____

Q2. What is your native language?

Chinese (Mandarin or dialect)

Other (please specify): _____

Q3. Which of the following best describes your general gaming habits in the past 6 months?

I play video games regularly ($\geq$5 hours per week)

I play video games occasionally (<5 hours per week)

I rarely play video games

Q4. Which of the following best describes your experience with narrative interactive games (e.g., interactive story games, choice-driven games)?

I often play narrative interactive games and am highly familiar with them

I occasionally play them

I have little to no experience with them

Q5. I want to continue participating in the interview research.

Yes

No

Thank you for your time and participation!

Appendix iii: Coding Scheme Description for *Road to Empress*

1. Introduction

This project investigates how players experience and evaluate an interactive historical drama game that centers on Wu Zetian, with a particular focus on how narrative design, historical adaptation, and gendered power relations are constructed and perceived in practice. We aim to develop a systematic and theoretically informed understanding of players' core concerns around pseudo branching and interaction design, historical authenticity and character construction, gender and power narratives, emotional engagement and immersion, and overall story quality and formal style.

2. Coding procedure

The coding procedure includes all steps for completing the analysis of comments and interview results. The procedure can be broken down in two main tasks: the classification of key words in comments, and the analysis of results from semi-structured interviews.

2.1 Codebook

Through readings of the full collection of player comments, the researchers inductively generated several first-order themes based on content similarity and existing theoretical concerns (e.g., interaction design, historical adaptation and character construction, emotional investment and immersion). These themes were then completed with the keywords obtained from the comments and specified into corresponding secondary level categories to capture more fine-grained analytical dimensions.

Table 1 shows the list of categories we will consider for comments related to *Road to Empress* on Steam.

2.2 Introduction to Coding Categories

In the second round of formal coding, the researchers used a repeatedly revised codebook to code the comments line by line, assigning codes to textual segments and, where appropriate, applying multiple codes to the same segment in order to preserve its layered meanings. Following the interviews, the researchers refined the main structure of the original codebook in light of the interview data and further elaborated the definitions of the second-order categories.

The current coding scheme is composed of 5 domains and 12 coding categories.

Domain 1 Pseudo Branches and Interaction Design

1.1 Historical Dependence Players criticize the ending branches for relying too heavily on established historical facts, which they feel restricts imagination and lead to a monotonous experience. In their view, the game's marketing emphasizes "multiple endings," yet the narrative remains tightly bound to the single historical outcome of Wu Zetian eventually becoming empress. Players argue that, since Wu Zetian is chosen as the protagonist, the design should strike a more reasonable balance between historical inevitability and narrative possibility, rather than simply treating all non-empress routes as bad endings.

Example: "I refused to give up — I'm stubborn, so I tried every single route to save Bianji, but every path still led to death. It was an immersive experience that truly showed me what it means to have no way out, to feel utterly powerless. Even when you give everything, even risk your own life, you still can't change fate. In the Forbidden City, there were too many things beyond one's control. When a person is tied to their family, they lose their ability to choose. I felt the helplessness of that era so deeply." (c14)

1.2 Pseudo Branches and Interaction Design Players repeatedly identify the phenomenon of "pseudo branching," whereby the game ostensibly presents a wide array of narrative routes, yet in practice funnels the majority of choices into a limited set of cumulative death endings. While the sheer number of branches is rhetorically emphasized in marketing discourse, players perceive the actual scope for consequential choice as highly constrained. This perceived discrepancy produces a sense of deceptive interactivity and a concomitant impression that players lack meaningful agency over the narrative trajectory.

Domain 2 Evaluation of Historical Adaptation and Character Construction

2.1 Historical Accuracy and Adaptation Many players think the game uses Wu Zetian mainly as a selling point while focusing on romance, with history and characters treated in a shallow and dramatized way. They feel the plot relies on sensational anecdotes and "unofficial histories," so the historical background becomes decorative. Some players also hope the game could help them rethink the real Wu Zetian and her political career, but believe this potential is not fully realized.

2.2 Protagonist Players criticize the romantic storyline between Li Tai and Wu Zetian as illogical and historically implausible, seeing it as distorting history for melodrama. They especially reject the premise that Wu Zetian does not become empress or that her political rise is downplayed, arguing this erases her ambition and turns a powerful historical woman into someone whose key political destiny is removed from both history and player choice.

Example: "What's the point of adding a Li Tai romance line? Isn't this essentially spreading a vulgar rumor about Wu Zetian? I don't think gaining Li Tai's affection makes Wu Zetian more valuable — since when does a woman become more attractive just because more men are chasing her?"

2.3 Supporting Characters By contrast, players generally appreciate minor characters such as Xixin, Rui'er, and Du Ruo, who are seen as logical, distinct, and grounded in everyday concerns. These "small" characters help build realism and emotional depth, allowing players to feel the broader social environment and moral ambiguity of the story world.

Example: "What's the point of adding a Li Tai romance line? Isn't this essentially spreading a vulgar rumor about Wu Zetian? I don't think gaining Li Tai's affection makes Wu Zetian more valuable — since when does a woman become more attractive just because more men are chasing her?"

Domain 3 Gender and Power Narratives

3.1 False Empowerment Players argue that rewriting Wu Zetian into a romance-driven heroine without clear ambition

Table 1: Domains and coding categories for Steam comments on *Road to Empress*

Domains	Categories	Brief description
Narrative Structure and Ending Design	**Historical Dependence**	Balance and tension between multi-ending design and fixed historical outcome; how strongly endings depend on history.
	Pseudo Branches Design	Presence of "fake" branching, stacked death endings, and limited real freedom of choice.
Evaluation of Historical Adaptation and Character Construction	**Historical Accuracy and Adaptation Approach**	Perceptions of historical authenticity and how the game adapts, simplifies, or dramatizes real history.
	Protagonist Construction	Assessment of Wu Zetian and core characters' motivations, coherence, and fidelity to history.
	Portrayal of Supporting Characters	Depth and realism in the depiction of minor and supporting characters.
Gender and Power Narratives	**False Empowerment**	Whether the game genuinely empowers female characters or symbolically weakens and depoliticizes them.
	Dual Standards in Gender	Gendered double standards in how ambition, power, and responsibility are written for male versus female characters.
Emotional Engagement and Immersion	**Emotional Involvement**	Emotional resonance, empathy, and information asymmetry between players and characters.
Emotional Engagement and Immersion	**Enhanced Immersion During Choices**	How interaction design and continuous visuals create a sense of presence and immersion.
Storytelling Quality and Formal Style	**Plot Logicality**	Overall evaluation of narrative logic, coherence, and originality.
	Dramatic Tension and Theatricality	Intensity of dramatic conflict, deaths, and thriller-like qualities.
	Interface and Production Quality	Perceived quality of interface, visuals, and atmosphere building.

or political agency amounts to false empowerment and erases the radical meaning of her historical power. Under the cover of fictional romance and a "new world line," the story shifts from political struggle to personal love, de-politicizing her and making the narrative feel like a step backward in gender representation, especially for a 2025 release.

3.2 Double Standards for Male Characters Players also point out gender double standards: if Wu Zetian can be written as "not wanting to be emperor, only wanting love," then male rulers should also be allowed to take the throne only for love, which exposes inconsistency in gender politics. They further criticize some male characters, especially the crown prince, as overly negative and one-dimensional, arguing this misrepresents historical complexity and creates an imbalanced configuration of gender and power.

Domain 4 Emotional Engagement and Immersion

4.1 Emotional Involvement Despite criticisms, many players report strong emotional involvement, including anger and helplessness due to information gaps between themselves and characters like Princess Gaoyang, which produces strong identification and empathy. They attribute this to a "long drama" visual texture, pacing, and atmospheric design that highlight immersion.

4.2 Immersion During Choices Players feel that continuous visual flow during decision points—without cutting to static menus—enhances the sense of presence and real-time decision making, making choice integration into scenes one of the game's formal strengths.

Example: "I refused to give up — I'm stubborn, so I tried every single route to save Bianji, but every path still led to death. It was an immersive experience that truly showed me what it means to have no way out, to feel utterly powerless.

Even when you give everything, even risk your own life, you still can't change fate. In the Forbidden City, there were too many things beyond one's control. When a person is tied to their family, they lose their ability to choose. I felt the helplessness of that era so deeply." (c42)

Domain 5 Story Quality and Formal Style

5.1 Plot Logicality Many players find the plot illogical and driven more by sensational events than coherent causality, which weakens trust in the story. They conclude that while the form (interactive structure and audiovisuals) feels new, the narrative content remains old-fashioned and formulaic.

5.2 Dramatic Tension The game is recognized as highly dramatic, with frequent deaths, twists, and confrontations that maintain suspense and emotional intensity, though this also heightens worries about plausibility and historical distortion.

5.3 Interface and Production Quality Players generally rate the interface and production quality as "top tier," praising the polished UI, scene pacing, and integration

Appendix iv [Recruitment] Duke University Research Team: Player Interviews on *Road to Empress* Storyline and Historical Experience

Dear *Road to Empress* players,

We are an undergraduate research team from **Duke University**. As players of *Road to Empress* ourselves, we are conducting an academic research project on "player experience and choice authenticity in historically adapted games."

During your playthrough, have you ever felt surprised by the game's reinterpretation of the historical image of **Wu Zetian**? Have you ever hesitated in front of certain plot options, or felt that some "inevitable death endings" were particularly hard to accept?

We are very eager to hear the voices of core players. Your genuine feedback will directly serve as data for our research and help the academic community better understand how players seek balance between "historical fidelity" and "game entertainment."

We are looking for participants who:

1. **Age:** 18–30 years old.
2. **Experience:** Have played *Road to Empress* (have completed the game or experienced most of the core storylines).
3. **Willingness:** Are willing to participate in about 20 minutes of online voice interview (conducted anonymously and used only for academic purposes).

How to participate: If you are interested in sharing your insights, please send an email to: **zw315@duke.edu (Contact: Ziying Wang)**. *In the email, please briefly indicate how you would like to be addressed and your approximate game progress. We will get back to you as soon as possible with specific interview details.*

This is a non-commercial academic activity. Although the interview is unpaid, we promise that your views will be carefully documented and will contribute to academic research in this field. Thank you very much for your support!

A Appendix iv Semi-Structured Interview Guide for *Road to Empress* Players

Research Project: Players' Agency and Perception of Authenticity in Historically Adapted Narrative Games
Target Participants: Chinese players aged 18–30 who have played *Road to Empress*
Interview Duration: Approximately 45–60 minutes

Part I: Opening and Warm-up (Warm-up & Background)

Goal: Build rapport and understand the player's "gaming history" and general preferences for historical games (Contextualization).

1. **Brief introduction:** Thank the participant for taking part, explain the purpose of the interview (to understand players' experiences with and perspectives on historical narrative games), and emphasize that there are no right or wrong answers; what we need is their genuine feelings.
2. **Gaming habits:**
   - What types of games do you mainly play in your everyday life?
   - Before playing *Road to Empress*, had you played any other games adapted from real historical events or based on real historical figures? (If yes, please give examples.)
   - How would you describe your cultural or ethnic background?
   - How familiar would you say you are with Chinese history or culture as represented in this game? (Not familiar / somewhat familiar / very familiar)

Part II: General Experience & Narrative Interpretation

Corresponding to RQ1: How do young Chinese players interpret key narrative elements in historically adapted narrative games?
Goal: Capture players' first impressions of the game's core narrative and of the character "Wu Zetian," without preimposing an evaluative stance.

3. **Character interpretation:**

    - As a character based on a famous historical figure, in what ways do you think the in-game version of Wu Zetian is similar to or different from the Wu Zetian in your own impression (or as depicted in history books)?

4. **Narrative evaluation:**

    - Were there any plots or moments in the game that made you feel particularly "immersed" or particularly "pulled out" of the experience? Please describe those scenes in detail.

Part III: Choice Authenticity & Player Agency

Corresponding to RQ2: How do these interpretations shape players' evaluation of "choice authenticity" and their perception of agency?
Goal: Explore in depth how players evaluate the process of "making choices," especially their views on whether options are reasonable and on "death endings."

5. **Choice experience:**

    - While playing, can you recall a moment when you found it **very difficult to make a decision**? What made you hesitate at that time?
    - Was there any moment when you felt that the options given by the game were **very unreasonable** or **confusing**?

      Follow-up: Why did you feel that option was unreasonable? Was it because it did not fit the situation at that time, or because it did not match the character's personality?

6. **Perception of agency:**

    - Throughout the whole game, how much control did you feel you had over the development of the story?
    - Some players mention that there are so-called "inevitable death options" or "fake branches" in the game (where the outcome is the same no matter what you choose). Did you encounter situations like this in the game?

      Follow-up: When this happened, how did you feel? Why do you think the game was designed this way?

7. **"If I were her" vs. "If it were me":**

    - When you were making choices in the game, were you more often basing them on "What would the historical Wu Zetian do?" or on "What would I myself (as the player) do?"
    - Did these two mindsets ever come into conflict during your playthrough?

Part IV: Tension Between Historical Authenticity and Entertainment

Corresponding to RQ3: How do players negotiate the tension between historical authenticity and entertainment value during gameplay?
Goal: Explore players' boundaries of acceptable "adaptation," and how "cultural proximity" influences their experience.

8. **Boundaries of adaptation:**

    - For a game based on real history, how much creative freedom do you think developers can have in terms of the storyline?
    - Are you comfortable with changing known historical facts in order to make the game "more fun" or "more dramatic"?

      Follow-up: Can you think of any specific examples where you felt the adaptation was "done well" or "completely unacceptable"?

9. **Historical inevitability:**

    - If, because "this is what actually happened in history," the game prevents you from achieving a perfect ending (for example, you are unable to save a certain character), how would you evaluate this kind of design?
    - Do you prefer that the game strictly follow historical outcomes, or that it allow players to rewrite history through their efforts?

Part V: Closing

Goal: Collect any missing information and confirm demographic information.

10. **Additional thoughts:**
    - Regarding the game's historical fidelity or gameplay design, is there anything we haven't talked about that you would especially like to share?
11. **Demographic confirmation:**
    - Confirm age range (18–30).
    - Confirm gender (optional).
12. **Thanks:** Thank the participant again for their time and valuable insights.

Interviewer Notes

- **Avoid assumptions:** Do not ask "Do you also think Li Tai's storyline is really terrible?", instead ask "How do you view Li Tai's storyline?"
- **Probe for deeper reasons:** When a player says "I don't like this design," ask at least one more "why," or "Could you describe more specifically what kind of feeling it gave you?" (Did you feel offended? Bored? Or pulled out of the experience?)
- **Pay attention to vocabulary:** Pay attention to whether players use terms like "OOC (Out of Character)," "radical rewriting ()," "respecting history," or "sense of immersion ()," and ask them to explain what these terms specifically mean to them.